TOPIC 1 · THE GLOBAL ECONOMY

ABC News (Laura Tingle, Antalya)
Thursday 12 November 2026

COP31: arguments over a global electricity target

> At the UN climate talks in Antalya, a push to lift electricity's share of world energy use to 35% by 2035 has divided countries over whether that power must be clean.

WHAT HAPPENED

- Türkiye's **"35 by 35"** pledge would lift electricity from about **23%** of world energy use to **35% by 2035**.
- Supporters say this means electrifying at about **four times** the current pace.
- The draft wording does **not require clean electricity** – the main sticking point.
- Analysts estimate a clean-only version could cut projected warming by **0.3°C**, from at least 2.6°C.
- Australia backs a voluntary pledge to double rooftop-solar households to at least **300 million by 2030**, joined by Bangladesh, Kenya, Nigeria, Palau and Vanuatu.

23%
Electricity's share of world energy use now

35%
Proposed share by 2035

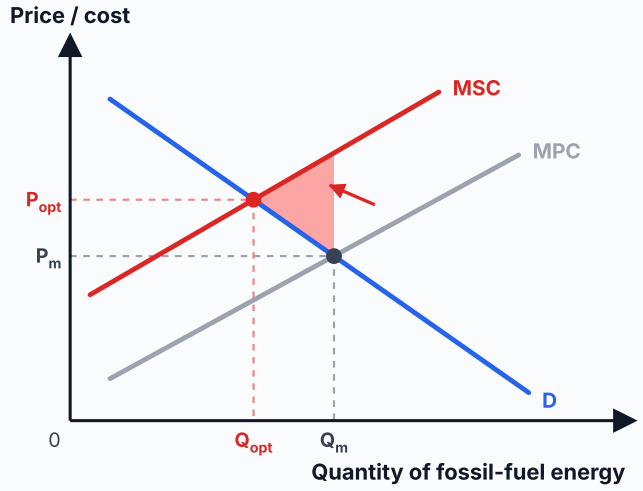
2.6°C+
Projected warming on current path

300m
Rooftop-solar households targeted by 2030

Negative externality: a cost imposed on third parties (e.g. climate damage) that is not reflected in the market price.
Voluntary pledge: a non-binding commitment with no penalty for missing it.

DIAGRAM

Why markets over-produce fossil-fuel energy



Firms base output on their private costs (**MPC**), so the market settles at Q_m. But burning fossil fuels imposes climate costs on others, so the true social cost is higher (**MSC**).

The efficient output is lower, at Q_{opt}. The red triangle is the **welfare loss** from over-production. Clean electrification shifts energy use away from this market.

Exam angle: Climate change is a **global** externality: no single country can fix it, and each has an incentive to free-ride. That is why the strength of the wording (binding or voluntary, clean or any electricity) matters.

BAR CHART

The electrification gap (electricity's share of world energy use)



Closing a 12-point gap in ten years means electrifying transport, heating and industry about **four times faster** than now. If that power comes from coal or gas, much of the climate benefit is lost.

SYLLABUS LINK
Topic 1 – Global environmental issues and sustainability; Topic 4 – environmental management policy and the limitations of international agreements.

TRY THIS
Assess the effectiveness of voluntary international agreements in addressing global environmental problems.
(6 MARKS)

Sources — ABC News, 'COP31 electric power target sparks row over cutting fossil fuel use': abc.net.au/news/2026-11-11/cop31-electrification-turkiye-australia/107371196

Figures as reported; diagrams are illustrative, not to scale.